

THE INDIAN CIVILIZATION AND CULTURE

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Born: 2nd Oct, 1869

Death: 30 Jan, 1948

About the Author / Key Facts

- He is popularly known as Bapu or the Father of the Nation.
- From 1915 till 1948, he completely dominated Indian politics.
- His autobiography: "My Experiments with Truth"
- He wrote many articles for Young India.
- Gandhi ji went to Champaran in 1917.
- This chapter is an essay.

Summary

Indian Civilization and Culture is an extract from the speech delivered by Mahatma Gandhi. In this extract, Gandhi talks about the sound foundation of Indian civilization and its moral being. Gandhi believes that Indian civilization can't be beaten in the world; its roots are very strong. It is the only civilization which is not affected by the materialistic attraction of modern civilization. We are proud of our culture and civilization.

Gandhi defines happiness as a mental state. It lies in satisfaction and restriction of our desires and passion. It consists in a proper use of our hands and feet. Our ancestors dissuaded us from luxuries and pleasures. They were satisfied with small villages. Our civilization is superior to western civilization. Our civilization is based on morality while western civilization is based on materialism.

Gandhi says that a certain degree of physical comfort is needed for sound health. But, above a certain level, man becomes a slave of his needs.

Important Points from Chapter

- Gandhi said nothing can equal the seeds sown by our ancestors. Rome and Greece went. Japan has become westernized. And Europeans learned their lesson from writings of the men of Greece or Rome.
- India remains immovable and that is her glory. According to Gandhi, the Gujarat equivalent for civilization means good conduct.
- Gandhi compares the human mind with a restless bird.
- European civilization will mean ruin for India. We must shun it at all cost.
- Attic civilization belongs to Greece.

According to Gandhi: Indian vs Western Civilization

Indian Civilization	Western Civilization
Based on morality	Based on materialism
Teaches self-control	Encourages endless desires
Promotes simplicity	Promotes luxury
Focuses on spiritual growth	Focuses on physical comfort

Thus, Indian civilization is superior because it builds character and moral strength.

Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

1. Who dominated Indian politics from 1915 to 1948?

- (a) J.L. Nehru
- (b) Sardar Patel
- (c) M. Gandhi
- (d) S.C. Bose

2. Simple living and high thinking is the base of ____.

- (a) Wanian Civilization
- (b) Indian Civilization
- (c) American Civilization
- (d) European Civilization

3. ____ prefers spiritualism to materialism.

- (a) Dr. Zakir Hussain
- (b) M. Gandhi
- (c) Dr. Rajendra Pd.
- (d) Indira Gandhi

Short Answer Questions

Q1. How is Indian civilization different from European civilization?

Ans. Indian civilization and European civilization are quite different from each other. The tendency of Indian civilization is to elevate the moral being. On the other hand, the western civilization propagates immorality. European civilization is godless; but Indian civilization is based on strong belief in God.

Q2. Why does Gandhi say that Mind is a restless bird? What makes the mind restless?

Ans. Mahatma Gandhi was a man of experience. He felt that mind is a restless bird because the more it gets, the more it wants, and still remains unsatisfied. Gandhi felt that the more we indulge in our passions, the more unbridled they become. The cause of mind being restless is the multiplication of our needs.

Q3. Why did our ancestors dissuade us from luxuries and pleasures? Did they do the right thing?

Ans. Our ancestors had observed life very closely. They found that happiness does not depend on wealth. It is because there are many rich people who are very unhappy. On the other hand, there are several poor men, who are happy. They felt that happiness is a mental experience. Observing all this, our ancestors dissuaded us from luxuries and pleasures. I think they were really right in their approach.